

BHASKAR PAUL

INDIAN PREMIER LEAGUE

INDIA AS CRICKET CENTRAL

Sixers arriving on a flying carousel, Bollystars and Big Biz dancing in the aisles, power czars and pompom girls–IPL turned the gentleman's game into a rave party. Everyone won.

BY AMITABH SRIVASTAVA

In the late '70s, when Australian media tycoon Kerry Packer came in with his millions to stir up the old world rhythms of cricket, it must have felt like a blast of rock music at a country do. Day-night matches, helmets, coloured clothing—the purists called it a "circus". But it brought in big money. Enough to attract star players, even if it was beyond the pale of cricket law. But if Packer was like a casino, the Indian Premier League was all of Las Vegas. Big and brash on a scale that happens only in India, it was a monsoon wedding of entertainment and commerce—there was, er, ladies sangeet too. Cricket in India was already a rich princely state eyeing the empire, but the IPL still pulled off the Packer's circus trick of asset monetisation on a humongous scale. Players were bought and sold like Picassos at Sotheby's. One came, a dozen followed. The purists feigned ritual suicide at the sacrilege—the short boundaries, the dancing girls,

DID YOU KNOW?

IPL's broadcasting rights were sold for $6 billion in 2023, outpacing even the English Premier League in per-match value. Its brand value of $11 billion made it the world's second richest

THE SUPER SIXES

- **For raw talent, it's good money, exposure, a chance to learn from top world players—and an avenue to potential stardom**
- **Unearths stars like Hardik Pandya, Surya Kumar Yadav**
- **Creates broader fan base, attracts younger spectators**
- **Besides T20 spinoff leagues elsewhere, spawns Pro Kabaddi League and the like for a string of other sports**